



long whiskers enable beaver to feel its way in the dark

American beaver

Castor canadensis

North America's largest rodent, the American beaver, is a nocturnal "engineer" that alters landscapes throughout the continent, aside from desert areas and northernmost Canada. This stocky, big-skulled aquatic mammal fells trees by gnawing through the trunks, then arranges them into dams across streams or rivers, or uses them to build lodges for shelter. Its flat, scaly tail and webbed hindfeet make it a graceful swimmer, and a waterproof coat protects it from the winter cold.

Woody diet

The beavers' long, orange incisors, which never stop growing, are perfectly suited to their diet of woody bark, twigs, and stems. They also eat cambium, a soft tissue under the bark; favorite sources include birch, alder, and aspen, which they often store as winter food.

They live in small colonies, led by a male and female who mate for life. The female gives birth to three or four fully furred kits between April and June. The kits leave after two years to form their own colonies.

Beavers make their lodges along banks or lake shores, the most impressive being the island lodges in the middle of ponds. With an entrance only accessible underwater, these are the safest refuges from predators such as wolves and coyotes. They tailor their dams to rates of water flow, building straight ones for slow-moving water, and curved ones for faster currents.

MASTER BUILDER

American beavers make their dams and lodges out of logs, branches, grass, and moss, plastered together with mud.



CLOSE LIPPED

Beavers close their lips behind their incisor teeth when underwater so they can still nibble and gnaw on branches and stems.

- ↔ 29–35 in (74–89 cm)
- ⚖ 24–57 lb (11–26 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌳 Woody bark, twigs, stems
- 🏠 🌊



North America

